ABSTRACT

In the digital age, online reviews and ratings significantly influence consumer purchasing decisions by shaping customer trust.

This study explores the factors that affect trust in online reviews, how consumers perceive these reviews, and the impact on their buying behavior.

Utilizing a mixed-method approach, data was collected through surveys and interviews with 20 active online shoppers. The findings reveal that customers rely heavily on detailed, balanced, and verified reviews, while concerns about fake or biased feedback diminish trust.

Trust in reviews strongly correlates with purchase intent, brand loyalty, and repeat buying.

The study highlights the importance of authenticity, transparency, and credible sources in building consumer confidence.

Recommendations include enhancing review verification processes, encouraging detailed customer feedback, educating users to identify genuine reviews, and active moderation by platforms.

These insights offer valuable guidance for e-commerce businesses seeking to strengthen their online reputation and foster consumer trust.

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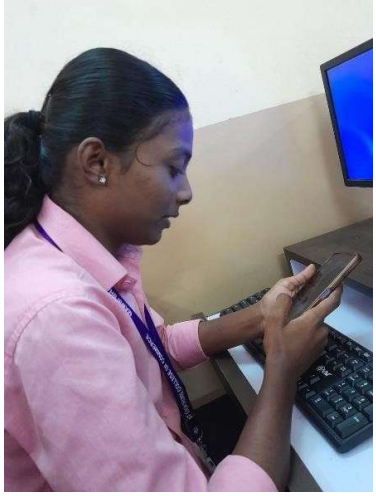
Building Trust in E-Commerce Through Mobile

Trust and Transparency in Online Shopping

Impact of Online Ratings on Buying Decisions



Influence of Customer Feedback on Purchase Behavior

Perception of Reliability in Online Reviews and Ratings

Chapter 1: Introduction

In today's digital era, online reviews and ratings play a crucial role in influencing customer purchasing decisions. With the rise of e-commerce and digital platforms, consumers increasingly rely on the experiences and opinions of other users to evaluate products and services. Customer trust in these reviews directly impacts buying behavior, brand reputation, and customer loyalty. However, the authenticity, reliability, and transparency of online reviews often come under scrutiny, making trust a critical factor for both consumers and businesses. This field project aims to explore the factors that shape customer trust in online reviews and ratings, understand how consumers perceive them, and examine the extent to which they influence purchasing decisions.

Trust is the cornerstone of any successful online business, and in the digital marketplace, it is primarily built or eroded through **customer reviews and ratings**. For a field project, exploring this topic offers a rich opportunity to understand how modern consumers make decisions. Online reviews act as a powerful form of social proof, providing a transparent, user-generated perspective that often carries more weight than a company's own marketing claims. They help potential buyers gauge the quality, reliability, and value of a product or service, thereby significantly reducing the perceived risk of a purchase.

You can delve into the specific elements that contribute to trust, such as the perceived authenticity of a review, the balance between positive and negative feedback, and the company's response to criticism. This research can provide valuable insights for businesses aiming to build a strong online reputation.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

Since 2021

The effect of online customer review and promotion through e-trust on the purchase decision of Bukalapakin Medan City

R Regina, ES Rini, BKF Sembiring - … of Research and Review, 2021 - researchgate.net

Since 2023

The effect of online customer review and online customer rating on the trust and interest of consumer purchases

P Purwantoro, Y Aini, H Hidayat… - JPPI (Jurnal …, 2023 - ipv6.jurnal.iicet.org

Since 2024

The Mediating Role Of E-Trust Between Online Customer Review, Online Customer Rating, And E-Service Quality On Customer Loyalty On The E-Commerce …

MM Octadyla, PCA Mismiwati - International Journal Of …, 2024 - pdfs.semanticscholar.org

Sort by relevance

Effect of Online Customer Review, Online Customer Rating, Online Trust, and Price on Interest to Buy Marketplace in Indonesia

IP Naomi, A Ardhiyansyah - Jurnal Sains Pemasaran Indonesia … - ejournal.undip.ac.id

Include patents

Effects of online reviews, trust, and picture-superiority on intention to purchase restaurant services

CW Park, I Sutherland, SK Lee - Journal of Hospitality and Tourism …, 2021 - Elsevier

Chapter 3:Methodology

3.1 Research Method:

This study uses a descriptive method to examine customer trust in online reviews. Surveys will gather quantitative data, and interviews will provide qualitative insights to identify factors affecting trust and its impact on purchases.

3.2 Tool Used:

◦ **Questionnaire :** A structured questionnaire was used to gather customer responses on trust in online reviews, including influencing factors, challenges, and purchase impact.

◦ **Interview :** Interviews were conducted to gather in-depth insights into customer experiences and perceptions of trust in online reviews.

◦ **Software/Apps:** Google Forms (for survey distribution), MS Excel/SPSS (for data entry and analysis), and Zoom/Google Meet (for conducting interviews).

3.3 Sample Size :

The study will be conducted with a sample size of 20 respondents, consisting of customers who actively use online platforms for shopping.

3.4 Sampling Method:

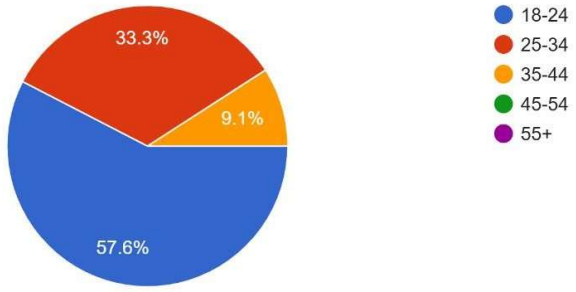
The study will use **convenience sampling**, selecting respondents who are easily accessible and actively engaged in online shopping platforms.

a) **Purposive Sampling:** This method will be used to specifically select respondents who actively read and rely on online reviews and ratings, ensuring the sample is relevant to the study objectives.
b) **Quota sampling:** This method will be applied to ensure representation from different groups, such as age, gender, or frequency of online shopping, so that the sample reflects diverse customer perspectives.
c) **Snowball Sampling:** This method will be used to reach additional respondents through referrals from initial participants, especially targeting customers who actively engage with online reviews and ratings.

3.5 DataAnalysis:

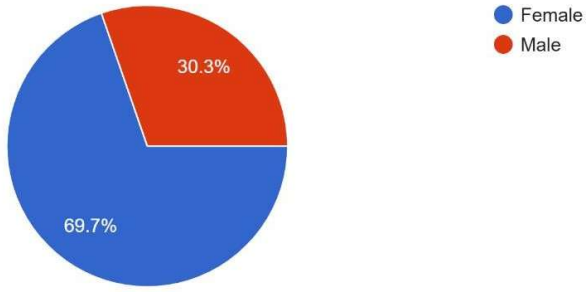
How old are you?

33 responses



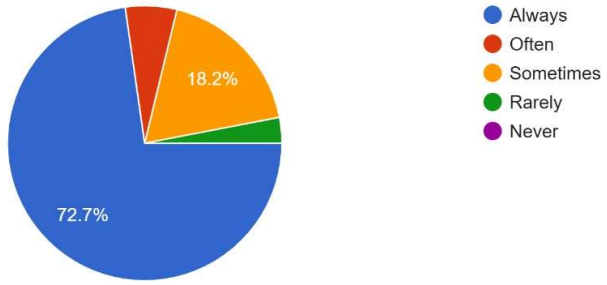
What is Your Gender?

33 responses



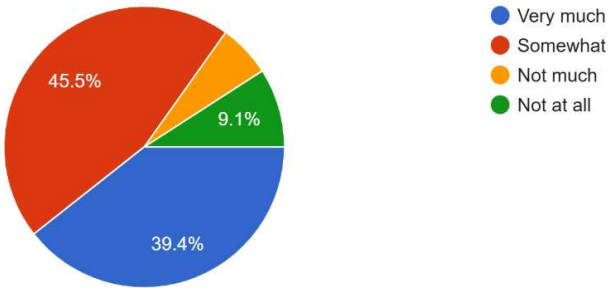
Do you read online reviews before making a purchase?

33 responses



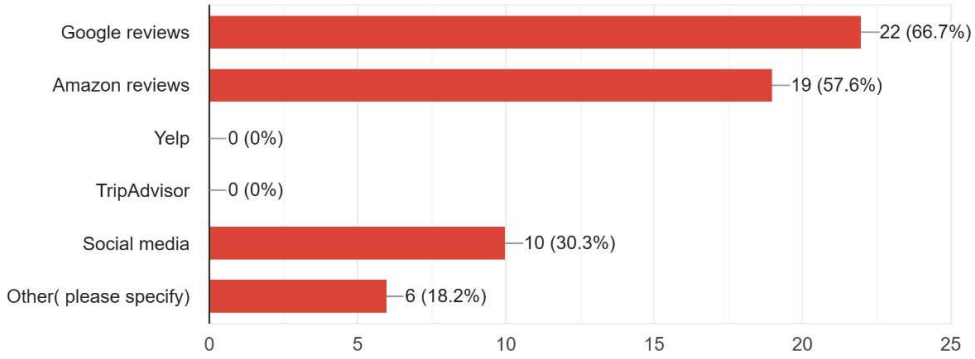
How much do online reviews influence your purchasing decisions?

33 responses



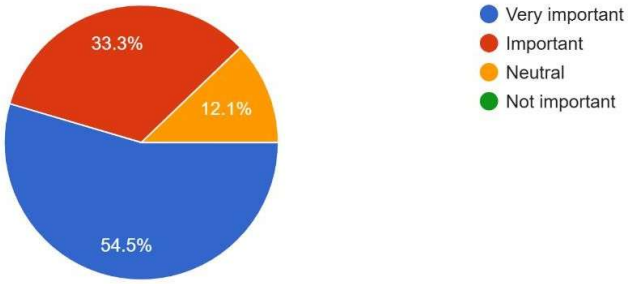
Which platforms do you trust most for online reviews? (Select all that apply)

33 responses



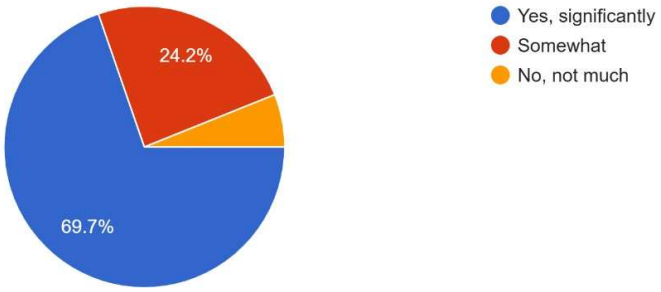
How important is it for you that reviews are from verified purchasers?

33 responses



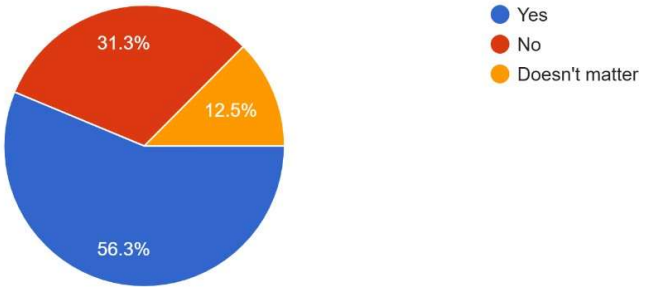
Does the number of reviews influence your trust in a product/service?

33 responses



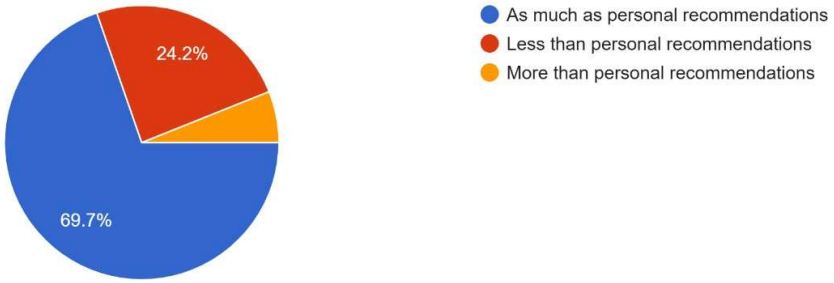
Do you prefer recent over older ones?

32 responses



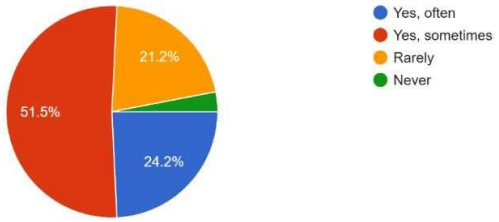
How much do you trust online reviews compared to personal recommendations?

33 responses



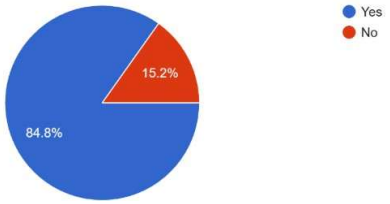
Have you ever suspected a review was fake?

33 responses



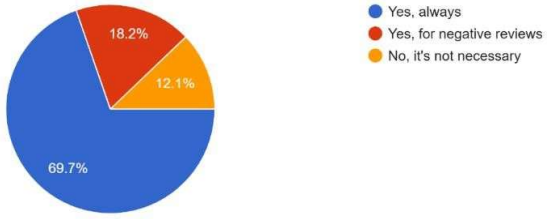
Have you ever decided not to purchase a product/service based on negative reviews?

33 responses



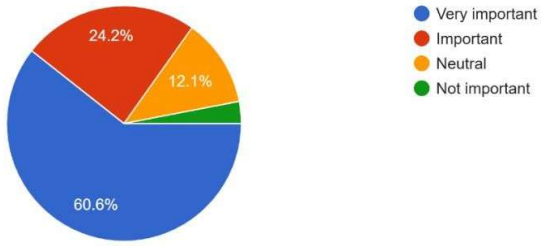
Do you think businesses should respond to online reviews?

33 responses



How important is transparency in how reviews are handled by businesses?

33 responses



Chapter 4:Field Work Description,Observation and Analysis

4.1 Field Work Description:

The field work for this study involved collecting data to understand customer trust in online reviews and ratings. A structured questionnaire was distributed to customers who frequently use online shopping platforms to gather quantitative data on factors influencing trust, challenges faced, and the impact of reviews on purchase decisions.

In addition to the survey, interviews were conducted with selected respondents to gain qualitative insights into their perceptions, experiences, and opinions regarding online reviews. These interviews helped capture deeper nuances of customer trust that the questionnaire could not fully reveal.

The collected data was organized, coded, and analyzed using statistical and thematic methods to identify patterns, relationships, and conclusions relevant to the study objectives. This combined approach ensured a comprehensive understanding of customer trust in online reviews and ratings.

4.2 Observations:

Based on the data collected from 20 participants, several key observations were made:

1. **Reliance on Online Reviews:** A majority of respondents indicated that they frequently check online reviews and ratings before making a purchase, highlighting their importance in decision-making.
2. **Trust Factors:** Customers tend to trust reviews that are detailed, have a balanced mix of positive and negative feedback, and come from verified buyers.

3. **Concerns About Authenticity:** Many respondents expressed concerns about fake or biased reviews, which sometimes reduces their confidence in relying solely on online ratings.
4. **Impact on Purchase Decisions:** Trusted reviews significantly influence customers' purchase decisions and brand loyalty, while suspicious reviews often lead to hesitation or seeking alternative sources.
5. **Platform Credibility:** Reviews on reputed and well-known e-commerce platforms were generally considered more reliable compared to lesser-known sites.

These observations highlight the critical role of trust in online reviews and the need for businesses to ensure authenticity and transparency to maintain customer confidence.

4.3 Analysis:

Always read online reviews before making a purchase, online reviews influence very much purchasing decisions, Google Reviews platforms I trust most for online reviews, Very important reviews are from verified purchasers, Yes, Significantly the number of reviews influence trust in a product/service, yes I prefer recent over older ones, I trust online reviews compared to As much as personal recommendations, yes often suspected a review was fake, yes I Have decided not to purchase a product/service based on negative reviews, I think yes always businesses should respond to online reviews, very important is transparency in how reviews are handled by businesses

Chapter 5: Conclusion and Recommendations

5.1 Conclusion:

Online reviews play a crucial role in shaping purchasing decisions, with platforms like Google Reviews being widely trusted due to their transparency and verification processes. Verified purchaser reviews and the quantity of reviews significantly impact consumer trust, while recent reviews are generally preferred over older ones. Consumers often value online reviews as much as personal recommendations but remain cautious about the authenticity of some reviews. Negative reviews can strongly influence decisions to avoid certain products or services. Therefore, it is essential for businesses to actively respond to reviews and maintain transparency in how they manage customer feedback to build and sustain trust.

5.2 Recommendations:

- **Enhance Review Authenticity:** Online platforms should verify reviewers to reduce fake reviews and increase trust.

- **Encourage Detailed Reviews:** Customers should be motivated to provide specific feedback about product quality, usage, and durability.

- **Educate Customers:** Awareness campaigns can help users identify genuine reviews and avoid biased or fake feedback.

- **Monitor and Moderate Reviews:** Platforms should regularly monitor reviews for authenticity and remove suspicious or misleading content.

- **Leverage Positive Reviews in Marketing:** Businesses can use credible customer reviews to boost brand reputation and influence purchase decisions.

References

ChatGPT: https://chatgpt.com/c/68d8fedf-fd64-832f-be7e-3f038c304d3b

Google Scholar: https://scholar.google.com/

Google Form Survey on Customer Trust in Online Reviews and ratings Google Form Link:

https://forms.gle/pULNEWpTvRi2WA6UA

Appedices

Appendix A- Guide Interaction Diary Form

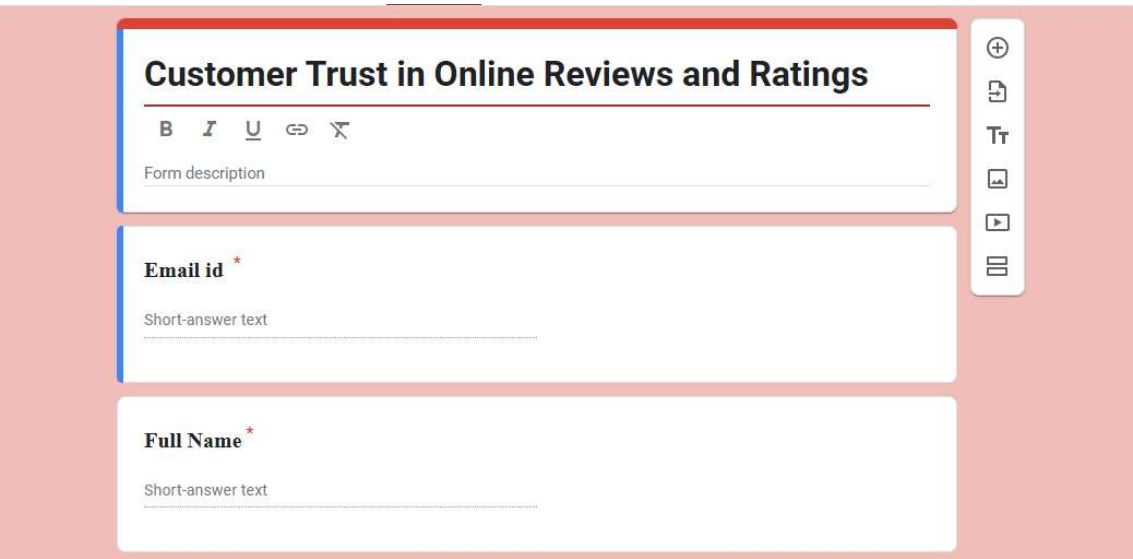
I,the undersigned Ms. Yelgam Pallavi Pandu Roll No.38 studying in the 2025-26 Year of Customer Trust in Online Reviews and Ratings Fulltime Course is doing my project work under the guidance of Ms. Ansari Nusrat, wish to state that I have met my Internal guide on the following dates mentioned below for Project Guidance:-

Sr.No.	Date	Signature of the Internal Guide
1	19th September 2025	
2	20th September 2025	
3	24th September 2025	

Signature of the Candidate

Signature of Internal Guide

Appendix B – Google Form Questions



Do you read online reviews before making a purchase?

- Always
- Often
- Sometimes
- Rarely
- Never

How much do online reviews influence your purchasing decisions?

- Very much
- Somewhat
- Not much
- Not at all

Which platforms do you trust most for online reviews? (Select all that apply)

- [ ] Google reviews
- [ ] Amazon reviews
- [ ] Yelp
- [ ] TripAdvisor
- [ ] Social media
- [ ] Other(please specify)

How important is it for you that reviews are from verified purchasers?

- Very important
- Important
- Neutral
- Not important

Does the number of reviews influence your trust in a product/service?

- Yes, significantly
- Somewhat
- No, not much

Do you prefer recent over older ones?

- Yes
- No
- Doesn't matter

How much do you trust online reviews compared to personal recommendations?

- As much as personal recommendations
- Less than personal recommendations
- More than personal recommendations

Have you ever suspected a review was fake?

- Yes, often
- Yes, sometimes
- Rarely
- Never

Have you ever decided not to purchase a product/service based on negative reviews?

- Yes
- No

Do you think businesses should respond to online reviews?

- Yes, always
- Yes, for negative reviews
- No, it's not necessary

How important is transparency in how reviews are handled by businesses?

- Very important
- Important
- Neutral
- Not important

Appendix C - Sample Data (in Excel table format)

	Timestamp	Full Name	Email ID
1.	17/09/2025 18:08:38	Mounika Deepak Chintakindi	mounikachintakindi47@gmail.com
2.	17/09/2025 18:11:44	Vishal Prabhakar Balla	ballavishal147@gmail.com
3.	17/09/2025 18:15:29	Shreya Chidurala	shreyachidurala123@gmail.com
4.	17/09/2025 18:15:46	Kalyani Jakkula	jakkulakalyani010@gmail.com
5.	17/09/2025 18:29:49	Goli sneha Naresh	snehagoli42@gmail.com
6.	17/09/2025 18:30:56	Adke Parshuram Raju	parshuramadike@gmail.com
7.	17/09/2025 18:42:44	Bhaskar Mote	bhaskar.mote@gmail.com
8.	17/09/2025 18:50:26	Domal Sravanti Satyanarayana	sravantidomal42@gmail.com
9.	17/09/2025 18:54:06	Yelgam Rekha Pandu	rekhapanduyelgam@gmail.com
10.	17/09/2025 19:03:09	Ramya laxman gajengi	ramyagajengi1407@gmail.com
11	17/09/2025 19:51:32	Kishan L Bura	kishan151093@gmail.com
12	17/09/2025 20:15:51	Rajeshwari gajula Janardhan	rajeshwarigajula1234@gmail.com
13	17/09/2025 20:16:11	Gajula Laxminarayana	laxminarayanagajula89@gmail.com
14	18/09/2025 07:25:49	Gajula Ramesh	gajularamesh5678@gmail.com
15	18/09/2025 18:22:47	Lavanya Yellaiah Chilukamari	chilukamarilavanya06@gmail.com
16	18/09/2025 21:14:26	Vallakati Rishikaa	rishikaa470@gmail.com
17	20/09/2025 23:59:09	Dyavanapelli Kirti	kirtuuu11@gmail.com
18	25/09/2025 16:09:38	Anupama sudhakar Karampuri	anupamakarampuri@gmail.com
19	25/09/2025 17:09:34	Sagar shrinivas yalgam	Sagaryalgam88@gmail.com
20	25/09/2025 18:18:30	Konda khushi	khushikonda9@gmail.com

STUDENT FEEDBACK ON FP

Student Name: Yelgam Pallavi Pandu

Seat No. /Roll No: 38

Email: yelgamp@gmail.com

Department: Bachelor of Science in Information Technology

Name of the Mentor: Ms.Ansari Nusrat

Title/Heading of Field Project: Customer Trust in Online Reviews and Ratings

Brief description of FP carried out: A focus group was conducted to investigate customer trust in online reviews and ratings. The discussion centered on how participants evaluate the credibility of reviews, their preferred platforms, and the role of verified purchaser feedback. The group explored factors influencing trust, such as the number and recency of reviews, suspicion of fake reviews, and the impact of negative ratings on purchase decisions. Additionally, participants shared their views on the importance of business transparency and responsiveness in managing online reviews. The insights gained highlighted key drivers of trust and the challenges customers face when relying on online reviews for decision-making.

Dates of FP: 4th September 2025 to 29th September 2025.

Was your internship experience related to your major area of study?

- Yes, to a slight degree

Indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statements.

This experience has:	Strongly Agree	Agree	No opinion	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
Given me the opportunity to explore a career field	✓				
Allowed me to apply classroom theory to practice		✓			
Helped me develop my decision-making and problem-solving skills		✓			
Expanded my knowledge about the work world before permanent employment		✓			
Helped me develop my written and oral communication skills		✓			
Provided a chance to use leadership skills (influence others, develop ideas with others, stimulate decision-making and action)		✓			
Expanded my sensitivity to the ethical implications of the work involved			✓		
Made it possible for me to be more confident in new situations		✓			
Given me a chance to improve my interpersonal skills		✓			
Helped me learn to handle responsibility and use my time wisely	✓				
Helped me discover new aspects of myself that I didn't know existed before		✓			
Helped me develop new interests and abilities		✓			
Helped me clarify my career goals			✓		
Allowed me to acquire information and/ or use equipment not available at my Institute			✓		
Allowed me to realize socio-economic issues in the society		✓			

● **In the Institute FP program, faculty members are expected to be mentors for students. Do you feel that your faculty mentor served such a function? Why or why not?**
Yes, I do feel that my faculty mentor served as a mentor in the FP program. They provided consistent guidance, clarified doubts, and offered valuable advice not only on academic matters but also on personal and career development. Their willingness to listen and support helped me feel more confident and motivated throughout the program.
● **How well were you able to accomplish the initial goals, tasks and new skills that were set down in your learning contract? In what ways were you able to take a new direction or expand beyond your contract? Why were some goals not accomplished adequately?**
I was able to accomplish most of the goals and tasks in my learning contract, especially in developing new skills like [insert key skill, e.g., communication or research]. I also expanded beyond the contract by exploring [new area/direction], which gave me broader learning. A few goals were not fully achieved due to [time constraints/unexpected challenges/priorities], but the experience still strengthened my adaptability and focus.
● **In what areas did you most develop and improve?**
I most developed and improved in communication skills, critical thinking, teamwork, and time management, which helped me handle tasks more confidently and effectively.
● **What has been the most significant accomplishment or satisfying moment of your FP?**
The most significant accomplishment of my FP was successfully completing my assigned project and applying the skills I learned in a practical way, which gave me a strong sense of achievement and confidence.
● **What did you dislike about the FP?**
I disliked the time constraints and workload pressure during the FP, which at times made it difficult to give equal focus to all tasks.
● **Considering your overall experience, how would you rate this FP? (Circle one). – Satisfactory/ Good/ Excellent 15 |17**
Satisfactory/Good/Excellent
● **Give suggestions as to how your FP experience could have been improved. (Could you have handled added responsibility? Would you have liked more discussions with your professor concerning your FP? Was closer supervision needed? Was more of an orientation required?)**
My FP experience could have been improved with **more regular discussions and feedback sessions with my professor**, which would have provided clearer guidance. A **slightly longer orientation** at the beginning would also have helped me understand expectations better. I feel I could have handled **some added responsibility**, as it would have given me more scope to apply my skills in real situations.

Signature of Student
Name: Yelgam Pallavi Pandu
Date: